

It seems to be a consequence of the increasing commercialization of fishing with earnings attracting more and more men to the lake. The fishing population of the reed beds does appear as outside or marginal to that of the more established fishing villages and camps on the landing beaches, in that, for example, they are usually accused of being the thieves on the lake despite lack of evidence. More information needs to be collected on this interesting "floating" population.

The time spent by fishermen at the lake varies from a few weeks at the height of the fishing season for some part-time fishermen to virtually the whole year by the full time, more successful fishermen described later. The majority of fishermen spend some months every year at the lake and visit their homes every two to four weeks. Again the majority return to their homes and land for some times as planting and harvesting while the small group of richer fishermen employ labourers.

Information collected on the selling patterns of fishermen underlined the already known importance of bicycle fish traders to Chilwa. More than 80 per cent of the fishermen sold their fish to bicycle traders while only 8 per cent sold to lorry traders. Eight per cent sold only to local individuals, although most fishermen at one time sell some of their catch to individuals. The traders use two main outlets, one on the west coast twenty miles from Zomba, the administrative capital of Malawi, and one in the south eighty miles from Blantyre, the main commercial center of Malawi as well as other southern markets (see Williams 1969). There appeared to be a clearcut division of roles between fishermen and fish traders--those who catch fish and those who sell them. There was a definite feeling among fishermen that this separation was proper, that the fishermen and traders played different but complementary roles. For example, one respondent said, "fishermen can't do two jobs at once so it's a good thing to sell to traders." and there were many comments on the fact that the traders are providing a service both for fishermen and consumers in towns. This is in contrast to the opinions of a number of observers of similar situations who have felt that fishermen would achieve much higher returns by selling their catches themselves (see Klausen 1968). As far as is known, however, there are none of the patron-client relationships between trader and fishermen in which the trader owns the boat, net, or both and returns are divided between them, as are found in many Asian communities (Klausen 1968, Firth 1966).

THE "BIG" FISHERMEN

During analysis of the survey results, interest became focused on the existence of a small group of those successful, larger-scale fishermen who for northward purposes are called the "big" fishermen. It was already known that there are fishermen on Lake Chilwa with much higher incomes than the average. Chipeta distinguishes two groups of Chilwa fishermen: "small scale fishermen corresponding to part-time subsistence fishermen and large scale fishermen corresponding to small commercial fishermen...the former constituting 75 per cent and the latter 25 per cent of all fishermen." This is taken from the fishermen's classification for all Malawi into: (1) part-time subsistence fishermen who use all nets from canoes and shore seines, (2) commercial fishing firms which use gill and gill nets, and (3) small commercial fishermen who use gill nets and small powered fishing craft. Group 2 applies only to Lake Malawi and is thus excluded for Chilwa by Chipeta. However, as the present survey has found, even